

KIAN RAVAEI

**MORGHE
SAHAR**

(BIRD OF DAWN)

Iranian Traditional
Song Arrangement
for Soprano, Alto Flute,
Violoncello, and Piano

(Score)

ÆI edition

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*Commissioned by the National Association of Teachers of Singing
and Cincinnati Song Initiative, with major support from Lori Laitman.*

PROGRAM NOTE

One of the most celebrated Iranian ballads, *Morghe Sahar* (*Bird of Dawn*) is widely regarded as the unofficial anthem for Iranian freedom. Its lyrics were conceived in response to the Iranian Constitutional Revolution of the early 20th-century, but present-day Iranians sing it as a rallying cry against Iran's tyrannical government—hoping that one day a bird of dawn will arise from the darkness of the night.

My arrangement is a tribute to the “Woman, Life, Freedom” movement, and dedicated to the memory of Jina Mahsa Amini. By adding harmony to a traditionally monophonic song, I sought to shroud the melody in a mournful veil, reflecting the sorrow of an oppressed people.

—Kian Ravaei

PRONUNCIATION GUIDE

Vowels	Consonants
a = mat	g = game
ā = fall	gh = like a guttural "g" (voiceless uvular plosive)
e = net	j = joy
ey = prey	kh = “ch” in the German word <i>dach</i> (voiceless uvular fricative)
i = ring	y = year
o = role	zh = “s” in <i>vision</i> (voiced postalveolar fricative)
oo = boot	(All remaining consonants are the same as in English.)

To aid with pronunciation, a spoken recording of the text may be accessed at:
kianravaei.com/downloads/morghe-sahar.mp3

duration ca. 7'

TEXT & TRANSLATION

Morghe Sahar

by Mohammad-Taqi Bahar

Morghe sahar nāle sar kon
Dāghe marā tāze tar kon
Zāhe sharar bār in ghafas rā bar shekan o
zir o zebar kon

Bolbole par baste ze konje ghafas darā
Naghme ye āzādiye noe bashar sarā
Vaz nafasi arseye in khāke toode rā por
sharar kon

Zolme zālem, jore sayād
Āshiyānam dāde bar bād
Ey khodā ey falak ey tabiat
Shāme tārike mā rā sahar kon

No bahār ast, gol be bār ast
Abre chashmam zhāle bār ast
In ghafas chon delam tang o tār ast

Shole fekan dar ghafas ey āhe ātashin
Daste tabiat gole omre marā machin
Jānebe āshegh negah ey tāze gol az in

Bishtar kon, bishtar kon, bishtar kon
Morghe bidel
Sharhe hejrān
Mokhtasar kon

Bird of Dawn

(translation by the composer)

Bird of dawn, sing your lament.
Renew my pain,
With a sigh that rains fire, break and overturn this
cage.

Flightless nightingale, escape from the cage,
Sing the song of human freedom,
From the breath of the masses, fill the open earth with
fire.

The cruelty of the cruel and the tyranny of the hunter
Have left my nest dwindling in the wind,
O God, O Universe, O Nature,
Turn our dark evening into dawn.

It is a new spring, the flowers have bloomed,
The clouds in my eyes are filled with dew,
This cage, like my heart, is suffocating and dark.

O fiery sigh, set this cage alight,
O hand of nature, do not trim the flower of my life,
O flower, give this lover a glance.

Make it longer! Make it longer! Make it longer!
You heartless bird,
The story of suffering and longing,
Make it brief!

IPA TRANSCRIPTION

Morghe sahar nāle sar kon
[mor.ge sæ.hær nɒ.le sær kon]
Bird of dawn, sing your lament.

Dāghe marā tāze tar kon
[dɒ.ge mæ.rɒ tɔ.ze tær kon]
Renew my pain,

Zāhe sharar bār in ghafas rā
[zɒ.he ʃæ.rær bɒr in ɡæ.fæs rɒ]
With a sigh that rains fire,

bar shekan o zir o zebar kon
[bær ʃe.kæn o zir o ze.bær kon]
break and overturn this cage.

Bolbole par baste ze konje ghafas darā
[bol.bo.le pær bæ.s.te ze kon.dʒe ɡæ.fæs dæ.rɒ]
Flightless nightingale, escape from the cage,

Naghme ye āzādiye noe bashar sarā
[næɡ.me.ɣe ɒ.zɒ.di.ɣe no.e bæ.ʃær sæ.rɒ]
Sing the song of human freedom,

Vaz nafasi arseye in khāke too de rā
[væz næ.fæ.si ær.se.ɣe in xɒ.ke tu.de rɒ]
From the breath of the masses, fill the open earth

por sharar kon
[pɒr ʃæ.rær kon]
with fire.

Zolme zālem, jore sayād
[zɒl.me zɒ.lem dʒo.re sæ.jɒd]
The cruelty of the cruel and the tyranny of the hunter

Āshiyānam dāde bar bād
[ɒ.ʃi.jɒ.næm dɒ.de bær bɒd]
Have left my nest dwindling in the wind,

Ey khodā ey falak ey tabiat
[ej xo.dɒ ej fælæk ej tæ.bi.æt]
O God, O Universe, O Nature,

Shāme tārike mā rā sahar kon
[ʃɒ.me tɒ.ri.ke mɒ rɒ sæ.hær kon]
Turn our dark evening into dawn.

No bahār ast, gol be bār ast
[no bæ.hɒr æst ɡɒl be bɒr æst]
It is a new spring, the flowers have bloomed,

Abre chashmam zhāle bār ast
[æb.re tʃæʃ.mæm zɒ.le bɒr æst]
The clouds in my eyes are filled with dew,

In ghafas chon delam tang o tār ast
[in ɡæ.fæs tʃɒn de.læm tæŋ ɒ tɒr æst]
This cage, like my heart, is suffocating and dark.

Shole fekan dar ghafas ey āhe ātashin
[ʃo.le fe.kæn dær ɡæ.fæs ej ɒ.he ɒ.tæ.ʃin]
O fiery sigh, set this cage alight,

Daste tabiat gole omre marā machin
[dæs.te tæ.bi.æt ɡo.le ɒm.re mæ.rɒ mæ.tʃin]
O hand of nature, do not trim the flower of my life,

Jānebe āshegh negah ey tāze gol az in
[dʒɒ.ne.be ɒ.ʃeg ne.ɡɒh ej tɒ.ze ɡɒl æz in]
O flower, give this lover a glance.

Bishtar kon, bishtar kon, bishtar kon
[bɪʃ.tær kon bɪʃ.tær kon bɪʃ.tær kon]
Make it longer! Make it longer! Make it longer!

Morghe bidel
[mor.ge bi.del]
You heartless bird,

Sharhe hejrān
[ʃær.he hedʒ.rɒn]
The story of suffering and longing,

Mokhtasar kon
[mox.tæ.sær kon]
Make it brief!

ANALYSIS

The melody of *Morghe Sahar* is written in the *dastgah Mahur*. It begins in the *gushe Daramad*, which shares its notes with the Western diatonic scale. In m. 76, the melody modulates to the *gushe Shekaste* (literally translated as “broken”). This *gushe* contains a *koron*, an Iranian microtone which is approximately a quarter-tone flat in relation to 12-tone equal temperament. The *koron* is approximated using a quarter-tone accidental.

Measure 87 includes an example of *tahrir*, a vocal embellishment used to heighten the expression of the melody. We return, or *foorood*, to the *gushe Daramad* in m. 94 before returning to *Shekaste* in m. 114. Measure 134 modulates to another *gushe* known as *Delkash*, which also contains a *koron*. The piece ends by returning to *Daramad*. (The tonal modulations in the melody are my own addition.)

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

My sincerest thanks to Farzad Amoozegar and Fariborz Azizi for lending their expertise in Iranian classical music, Richard Pearson Thomas and Don Freund for their guidance in vocal writing, Valerie Coleman for her guidance in flute writing, and Carmen Edano, Allison Charney Epstein, Tivoli Treloar, and Gabrielle Turgeon for their suggestions regarding the voice part.

(Transposed)

to the memory of Jina Mahsa Amini

MORGHE SAHAR

(Bird of Dawn)

Words by Mohammad-Taqi Bahar
Melody by Morteza Neidavoud

Arranged by
Kian Ravaei (2025)

Gentle, un poco moto
 $\text{♩} = 42$ ($\text{♩} = 126$)

p mournful

Soprano
Mor - ghe sa - har nā - le sar

Alto Flute

Violoncello

Piano
inner voice *pp*
outer voices *p*

Red.

7

S.
kon_____ Dā - ghe ma - rā

imitate sound of a Persian Ney (wide vib., husky tone)
grace notes extremely fast and light (a flick of the finger, à la Persian ornamentation)
notated rhythm is an approximate guide; it should sound improvisatory

A. Fl.
p espr.

Vc.

Pno.
(*l.v. sempre*)

(*Red.*)

12

S. *tă - ze tar kon*

A. Fl.

Vc.

Pno.

p

p *sonore*

ten.

(Red.)

18

S. *Ză - he sha - rar bār in gha - fas*

A. Fl.

Vc.

Pno.

pp *p dolce*

(Red.)

25

S. *rā* *bar she - kan o*

A. Fl. *p*

Vc. *p* *sonore* *ten.*

Pno. *(Red.)*

30

S. *zir* *o ze - bar* *kon*

A. Fl.

Vc. *pp* *p* *I* *ten.*

Pno. *pp* *(Red.)*

37

S. *p* mournful
Bol - bo -

A. Fl.

Vc. *p cant.*

Pno. *p dolce*

43

S. -le par bas - te ze kon - je gha - fas da -

A. Fl.

Vc.

Pno. (Led.)

48

S. *mf*
-rā Nagh - me -

A. Fl. *p* 3

Vc.

Pno. (Led.) 8

52

S.
-ye ā - zā - di - ye no - e ba - shar sar - ā

A. Fl.

Vc. *pp* *p dolce* 3 I

Pno. (Led.)

58

S. *p* Vaz na - fas - i

A. Fl. *p*

Vc.

Pno.

(Red.)

62

S. *f* ar - se - ye in khā - ke too - de rā

A. Fl.

Vc. *p* *mf* *f*

Pno. *f*

(Red.)

rit.
***p* sub.**

a tempo

68

S. *por* *sha - rar* *kon*

A. Fl.

Vc. *p* *mf cant., sorrowful*

Pno. *p* *mf*

(Led.)

73

S. *mf angry*
Zol - me zā - -

A. Fl.

Vc. *f* *mf*

Pno. *f* *mf*

(Led.)

78 (C quarter-sharp)

S. - lem jo - re sa - -

A. Fl. *mf* angry

Vc.

Pno.

82 (C quarter-sharp)

S. - yād

A. Fl. *mf*

Vc.

Pno.

85 *espr.* **hold back**

S. *Ā - shi - yā - - nam _____ dā - de bar _____*

A. Fl.

Vc.

Pno.

91 **a tempo** *p* **sorrowful, hopeless**

S. *bād _____ Ey kho - dā _____*

A. Fl. *mf* *p*

Vc. *pp* *p dolce*

Pno. *p*

96

S. *ey fa - lak ey ta - bi - at*

A. Fl.

Vc. *mf p*

Pno. *(Red.)*

hold back a tempo

poco rit.

102

S. *Shā - me tā - ri - ke mā rā sa - har*

A. Fl.

Vc.

Pno. *pp*

(Red.)

a tempo

109

pp

S. *kon*

A. Fl. *pp* *cresc.* *3* *5* *6* *7* *7* *harmonic gliss.*

Vc. *pp* *cresc.* *5* *f*

Pno. *cresc.* *3* *5* *6* *5*

113

mf *hopeful*

S. No ba - hār ast,

A. Fl. *f* *3* *p sub.*

Vc.

Pno. *f* *p sub.* *espr., à la Persian ornamentation*

119 (B quarter-flat) *mf*

S. *gol be bār ast Ab - re*

A. Fl.

Vc.

Pno.

(Red.)

125 *espr.*

S. *chash - mam zhā le*

A. Fl.

Vc.

Pno.

(Red.)

hold back a tempo

130 *p*

S. *bār* *ast*

A. Fl. *p*

Vc. *p* *sonore*

Pno. *p* (Led.)

(E quarter-flat)

134 *mf* *anguished (not quite full voice)*

S. *In* *gha - fas* *chon* *de - lam* *tang* *o*

A. Fl. *mf* 3

Vc.

Pno. *mf* (Led. as needed)

139 *espr.*

S. *tār* *ast* (A quarter-flat)

A. Fl. *mf* *f* 3 (E quarter-flat)

Vc. *f* 3

Pno.

Red.

142 *f* desperate (full voice)

S. Sho - - - le fe - - kan

NB: grace notes change accidentals almost every bar
do not synchronize with cello

A. Fl. imitate sound of a Persian Kamancheh (poco flautando, husky tone)
grace notes extremely fast and light (a flick of the finger, à la Persian ornamentation)
notated rhythm is an approximate guide; it should sound improvisatory
NB: grace notes change accidentals almost every bar
do not synchronize with flute; change bows as needed

Vc.

Pno. *f* pesante

Red. as needed

144

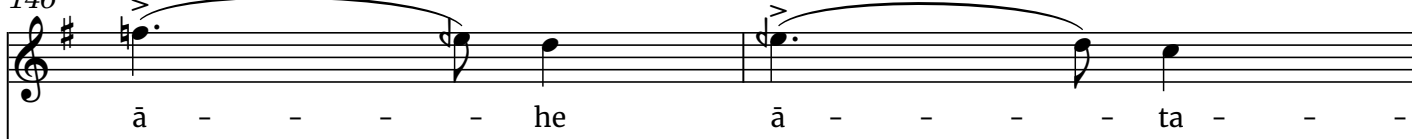
S. 
 dar gha - - fas ey
 (courtesy grace note accidentals)
 (D $\flat$, B $\sharp$) (D $\sharp$, B $\sharp$)

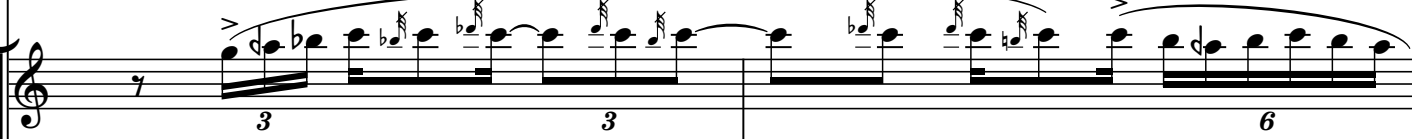
A. Fl. 
 (courtesy grace note accidentals)
 (A $\flat$, F $\sharp$) (A $\sharp$, F $\sharp$)

Vc. 
 (A $\flat$, F $\sharp$) (A $\sharp$, F $\sharp$)

Pno. 

146

S. 
 ā - - - he ā - - - ta - - -
 (D $\flat$, B $\flat$) (D $\flat$, B $\sharp$)

A. Fl. 
 3 3 6

Vc. 
 (A $\flat$, F $\sharp$) (A $\flat$, F $\sharp$)

Pno. 

148

S. *- shin*
(A quarter-flat, F $\flat$)

A. Fl.

Vc. *p* *f* 6

Pno.

150

S. Das - - - te ta - - bi - - -
(D $\sharp$, B $\sharp$)

A. Fl. 3

Vc. (A $\sharp$, F $\sharp$)

Pno.

152

S. *at* *gol* *e* *om*

(D $\flat$, B $\flat$) (D $\flat$, B $\natural$)

A. Fl.

Vc. 3 (A $\flat$, F $\natural$) (A $\flat$, F $\sharp$) 3

Pno.

154 *ff*

S. *re* *ma* *rā* *ma*

(D $\natural$, B $\natural$) (D $\flat$)

A. Fl.

Vc. (A $\natural$, F $\sharp$) (A $\flat$, F $\natural$)

Pno.

156 hold back

S. *- chin*
(Gb, Eb)

A. Fl.

Vc. *ff pesante*

Pno.

a tempo

159 *f*

S. *Jā - - - ne - be ā - - - shegh - ne -*

A. Fl.

Vc. (Ab, F#) *p sotto voce, but intense* 3 (Ab, F#) 3

Pno. (*f pesante*)

162

S. - gah ey tā - ze gol az

A. Fl.

Vc. (A $\flat$, F $\sharp$) (A $\flat$, F $\sharp$) (D $\flat$, B $\flat$) (D $\sharp$, B $\flat$)

Pno.

f

sf

5

3

165

S. in

A. Fl.

Vc. *p*

Pno. *p* dolce

172 *p* hopeless

S. *Bish* *tar* *kon,* *Bish* -

A. Fl.

Vc. *p cant.*

Pno. *ten.* *ten.*

Red.

179

S. - *tar* *kon,* *Bish* - *tar*

A. Fl.

Vc.

Pno. *ten.*

(Red.)

hold back a tempo

186

S. kon_ Mor - ghe bi - -

A. Fl. *p cant.*

Vc. *ten.*

Pno. (Led.)

hold back a tempo

192

S. - del_ Shar - he hej - -

A. Fl. *p*

Vc. *p*

Pno. (Led.)

hold back a tempo rit. *pp a piacere*

198

S. *-ran* *Mokh - ta - sar,* *mokh - ta - sar*

A. Fl. *p*

Vc. *p*

Pno. *(Ped.)*

a tempo

205

S. *kon*

A. Fl. *p cresc.*

Vc. *p cresc.* *ff*

Pno. *ff* *f cresc.*

Slower, freely

23

rit.

$\text{♩} = 40$ ($\text{♩} = 120$)

pp mournful

208

S. *ff* *mf* *sub.* *p* *mournful*

A. Fl.

Vc.

Pno.

Mor - ghe bi - del_____

215

S. *rit.*

A. Fl.

Vc.

Pno.

Shar - he hej - ran_____ Mokh - ta - sar, mokh - ta - sar

223 **a tempo**

S. *kon.*

A. Fl. *p*

Vc. *p* rumbling, ominous

Pno. *pp* *p* rumbling, ominous *(pp)*

Red. *Red. al fine*

227 **rit. al fine**

S.

A. Fl. *p* *pp*

Vc. *morendo al fine*

Pno. *p* *morendo* *ppp*

